CULTIVATING A GROWTH MINDSET

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 15

A conversation about learning, useful feedback, and progress within real constraints.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

RMP Day 15 | Week 3: Set boundaries. Explore learning through challenges, inspired by Dr Gemma Leigh Roberts's Cultivating a Growth Mindset.

Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

Notice mindset moments: explore how self-narratives affect a response to unfamiliar work without labeling people.

Learn through challenge: distinguish useful effort, new strategies, and support from simply working harder.

Use feedback and setbacks: consider how evidence and specific feedback can improve the next approach.

Make progress visible: look beyond an immediate outcome to learning quality and responsible next decisions.

Create conditions for growth: connect development to safe practice, boundaries, time, resources, and leadership support.

Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of growth mindset as openness to developing capability through strategies, feedback, and support, not pressure to stay positive or accept every demand. They discuss how learning and honest boundaries can reinforce each other. There are no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments.

Suggested 90-minute conversation

Time	Conversation topic	Question at its heart
0-8	Welcome, objectives, and opening round	What makes an unfamiliar task feel learnable?
8-20	1. Notice the story around a challenge	What stories do we tell ourselves when a support problem feels beyond our current expertise?
20-32	2. Change the strategy, not just the effort	When more effort is not producing progress, what else could change?
32-44	3. Turn feedback into useful information	What makes feedback useful enough to change our next attempt?
44-56	4. Learn from a setback without romanticizing it	What helps a failed hypothesis become useful information rather than a judgment of ability?
56-68	5. Recognize progress beyond the final result	What evidence shows learning when the customer outcome is not yet resolved?
68-80	6. Make growth possible within boundaries	What does a team need to provide so that learning is possible alongside live support responsibilities?
80-90	Key takeaways and lessons learned	What changed or expanded our thinking?

Use: a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not the source's chapter structure.

2. Conversation: mindset moments and learning strategies

Topic 1 | Notice the story around a challenge - 8-20 min

Learning objective: Recognize a limiting interpretation without assigning a fixed identity.

Open the conversation: *"What stories do we tell ourselves when a support problem feels beyond our current expertise?"*

Follow the conversation:

- How does saying this is unfamiliar differ from saying I am not capable?
- Can the same person approach one task openly and another defensively?
- What would a more accurate account include about experience, context, and support?

If a concrete example helps: After struggling with a new product area, an engineer concludes they are not suited to escalation work. Ask: What facts support that broad conclusion, and what more specific description would leave room for development?

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of labeling someone as fixed or growth-minded, what interpretation is shaping this particular moment?"*

Learning point to draw out: Mindset can vary with the situation. A specific, accurate account of a skill gap is more useful than a permanent judgment about a person.

Topic 2 | Change the strategy, not just the effort - 20-32 min

Learning objective: Connect learning to deliberate approaches and appropriate help.

Open the conversation: *"When more effort is not producing progress, what else could change?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What would help distinguish a knowledge gap from missing context or a poor approach?
- Which colleague, approved resource, or narrower question could make learning more effective?
- How do we know when continued solo effort is costing too much customer time?

If a concrete example helps: An engineer spends hours rereading the same logs without narrowing the question. Ask: What could a different comparison, clearer hypothesis, or consultation add that more hours alone might not?

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than prescribe more effort, what strategy or resource could change the quality of learning?"*

Learning point to draw out: Growth is not effort alone. Effective strategies, feedback, and help matter, and seeking expertise can be the responsible next move.

3. Conversation: feedback and setbacks

Topic 3 | Turn feedback into useful information - 32-44 min

Learning objective: Explore feedback without treating it as a verdict or requiring agreement with every comment.

Open the conversation: *"What makes feedback useful enough to change our next attempt?"*

Follow the conversation:

- Which observation or example would make a general comment actionable?
- How can we ask for clarification without turning the exchange into a defense?
- How do we assess feedback fairly when it is vague, conflicting, or missing context?

If a concrete example helps: A reviewer says an investigation needs more structure. Ask: What specific example, desired decision, or missing connection could the engineer ask about before deciding what to change?

If the discussion drifts: *"What information would help the next attempt, rather than settle whether the engineer is good or bad?"*

Learning point to draw out: Useful feedback describes something that can be understood and improved. Openness does not require accepting every interpretation uncritically.

Topic 4 | Learn from a setback without romanticizing it - 44-56 min

Learning objective: Separate learning and accountability from blame or unsafe experimentation.

Open the conversation: *"What helps a failed hypothesis become useful information rather than a judgment of ability?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What did the evidence rule out, and what uncertainty remains?
- What should be acknowledged if an action caused impact or missed a safeguard?
- How do we keep learning in approved environments rather than experiment on a live customer?

If a concrete example helps: An approved diagnostic test does not support the suspected cause. Ask: What has been learned, how should the working explanation change, and what next step remains proportionate to the risk?

If the discussion drifts: *"We do not need to call every setback a success. What can we learn, and what responsibility remains?"*

Learning point to draw out: A setback can inform a better approach without being desirable. Learning and accountability belong together; safeguards still apply.

4. Conversation: progress and growth conditions

Topic 5 | Recognize progress beyond the final result - 56-68 min

Learning objective: Evaluate developing capability without confusing activity with improvement.

Open the conversation: *"What evidence shows learning when the customer outcome is not yet resolved?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What question, explanation, or decision is clearer than before?
- How can we recognize a better approach without rewarding busyness alone?
- Which results depend on factors outside an individual engineer's control?

If a concrete example helps: A case remains open, but the engineer has narrowed the affected scope and removed an unsupported assumption. Ask: What genuine progress is visible, and what still must happen for the customer?

If the discussion drifts: *"What has become more accurate or useful, and what remains unresolved?"*

Learning point to draw out: Learning progress and customer resolution are related but different. Recognize improved reasoning without presenting an unfinished outcome as complete.

Topic 6 | Make growth possible within boundaries - 68-80 min

Learning objective: Identify the shared conditions that support learning without unlimited workload.

Open the conversation: *"What does a team need to provide so that learning is possible alongside live support responsibilities?"*

Follow the conversation:

- Where are time, coaching, access, or safe practice missing?
- How can an engineer ask for support or a smaller learning step without seeming unwilling?
- When is the problem workload or a system constraint rather than an individual's mindset?

If a concrete example helps: An engineer is encouraged to learn a new service while maintaining a full queue with no protected time. Ask: What priority, coverage, or coaching decision would make the expectation realistic?

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of asking for more positivity, what resource, boundary, or leadership decision would make learning feasible?"*

Learning point to draw out: A growth mindset does not remove real constraints. Sustainable development needs opportunity, support, and honest limits as well as willingness.

5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: "This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."

Use a short opening round: *"What makes an unfamiliar support task feel learnable rather than like a verdict on ability? A short observation is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for 6-10 participants. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

What you notice	A useful moderator phrase
The same people answer first	"Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic."
A quieter participant has not had space	"Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine."
A speaker runs long	"Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you want us to take from that?"
The conversation becomes a detailed case review	"We do not need to diagnose anyone's mindset. What story, learning strategy, or work condition does this situation reveal?"
A person or region is blamed	"Let us examine work conditions and behaviors, not judge a person or team. What would help any engineer here?"
Participants disagree	"What is each view protecting, and what do we understand differently after hearing both?"
Discussion moves to an unrelated issue	"That matters. Can we connect it to today's question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?"
There is silence	"Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?"

Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: "I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]." Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

Boundaries: arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table. Do not diagnose mindset, require personal disclosures, or frame overwork and unsafe experimentation as proof of willingness to grow.

6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- Treat mindset as a response to a situation, not a permanent label for a person.
- Pair useful effort with better strategies, feedback, resources, and timely help.
- Use specific feedback and setbacks as information while retaining accountability and safeguards.
- Recognize clearer reasoning and better decisions without confusing activity with progress or resolution.
- Support growth with time, coaching, safe practice, and realistic boundaries; positivity cannot replace resources.

Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

A participant might say...	Connection to the learning objective
"This was a skill I had not developed yet, not proof I could never do it."	Mindset moments: replace a broad identity judgment with a specific development need.
"A different question and expert input helped more than another hour alone."	Strategy: connect effort to resources and a more effective approach.
"The learning expectation needed protected time, not more encouragement."	Growth conditions: identify organizational support and realistic limits.

Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

Closing thought: *"Growth is not saying yes to every challenge. It is staying open to learning and making the strategies, support, and limits clear enough for progress."*

Source and adaptation note

Inspired by Dr Gemma Leigh Roberts, Cultivating a Growth Mindset (42m), assigned for RMP Day 15. The public course overview and visible contents were reviewed November 10, 2026; the complete course was not reviewed. Questions, examples, and moderator guidance are original support adaptations, not a reproduction of course exercises, a neuroscience lesson, or an assessment of participants.

RMP program materials | Course overview